CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 03

WEEK OF 23 NOVEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



RETAIL

Keep the shutters up.

Payment outages, cyber attacks, abuse on the shop floor, lockdowns and warm freezers. How to keep stores trading and colleagues safe when it goes wrong at peak.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

Contents

A practical playbook for retail resilience leaders: how stores and head office work as one when tills, systems, fridges or people are under threat, with a peak trading plan for Black Friday and Christmas.

Foreword 03

Introduction 04

01 Ready for peak 06

02 When it happens 14

03 Recover and rehearse 24

Readiness assessment and buyer's guide 35

Sources 37

FOREWORD

Retail crises rarely start at head office. They start at a till, a freezer or a shop door.

In April 2025 a cyber attack forced Marks and Spencer to pause online orders for 46 days, and the retailer estimated the hit to operating profit at around £300m before mitigation.[1,2] The Co-op shut down systems to contain a parallel attack, lost an estimated £206m of sales in six months and later confirmed that data on all 6.5 million members had been taken.[3,4] In October 2026 an incident at Ahold Delhaize took online grocery services offline in the Benelux and the US; the group now expects fourth-quarter sales to be €200m to €250m lower.[5]

The same month, attackers switched supermarket refrigeration into defrost from the internet. France's CERT-FR reported numerous compromised controllers, and on 2 November a second wave reached stores in Ireland, Belgium and Sweden and food suppliers in the UK.[6,7] Meanwhile, the BRC counts more than 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff every day.[8]

This playbook is for the people who have to hold it all together: resilience, security, store operations, IT and communications leaders. It sets out how a store and head office should work as one team on the worst day of the year, who decides what, what to have ready before Black Friday and the messages to send in the first hour. It also gives you tools to use straight away: a roles matrix, an escalation workflow, store logs, a tabletop exercise and a review template. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things keep a store trading on a bad day.

Retail incidents move fast and land on the shop floor first. The retailers that cope best are not the ones with the thickest manuals. They are the ones where stores and head office already know who decides, how they talk and what each store does without being asked.

One incident, one team

A store manager and the head office incident lead share the same severity scale, the same facts and the same clock. Nobody waits for a meeting to start.

Fast, two-way messages

Head office can reach every store, and every store can reach head office, in minutes, with a record of who has read what and who has not.

People before stock

Every procedure starts with colleague and customer safety, from a queue that turns hostile to a lockdown call or a freezer that cannot be trusted.

A store that cannot take payment is not trading. It just has the lights on.

The hardest retail incidents are the ones that turn an IT problem into a shop floor problem within minutes: long queues, angry customers and colleagues left to explain something nobody has told them.

PART 01

Ready for peak.

Decide now how stores and head office will work together, how you will grade an incident and what must be true before Black Friday.

01 Store and head office as one team

02 Six threats, first actions

03 A retail severity ladder

04 Who does what, and who decides

05 Escalating from store to head office

06 Peak readiness in six steps

READY FOR PEAK

One incident, two worlds: the store and head office

> **Every head office decision has a store consequence, and someone must own telling stores about it.**

A retail incident is lived in two places at once. At head office, it is a dashboard turning red, a bridge call and a decision about which systems to switch off. In the store, it is a queue that will not move, a customer who wants to know why and a manager who has heard nothing.

The 2025 attacks showed how quickly the two worlds connect. M&S first disclosed a cyber incident after problems with contactless payments and click and collect over the Easter weekend, and stopped taking online orders three days later.[2] The Co-op said it kept trading while it contained its attack, but had to deal with payment problems and empty shelves along the way.[3]

The decisions that protect the business at head office are often the ones that hurt stores most. Taking systems offline can stop an attacker. It can also stop stock files, price updates, loyalty scanners and delivery slots. When Ahold Delhaize took systems offline as a precaution in October 2026, stores stayed open but some shelf labels showed out-of-date promotional prices and loyalty scanners failed.[9]

So the first rule of retail incident management is that every head office decision has a store consequence, and someone must own telling stores about it. The second is that information must flow upwards as well as down. Store managers see the effects first: the first declined card, the first fridge alarm, the first group of shoplifters who turn aggressive. They need a fast, simple way to raise it and to know it has landed.

That means one severity scale that stores and head office both use, one place where the facts live, scheduled updates even when there is nothing new, and acknowledgement from every store so you know who has not heard. It also means trusting store managers with clear authority to act on safety without waiting for permission: to close a door, stop a queue or take stock off sale.

None of this needs to be built during an incident. It needs to be agreed, written down and rehearsed before the busiest weeks of the year.

SIX THREATS

Six retail threats and the first moves that matter

What each side does in the first five minutes, without waiting to be told.

THREAT	FIRST STORE ACTION	FIRST HEAD OFFICE ACTION
Till or payment outage	Switch to the cash and offline procedure. Stop restarting terminals. Tell customers what works.	Confirm scope. Send one instruction to all stores with the next update time.
Cyber attack on core systems	Trade on what still works. Report anything odd. Do not reset devices unless told.	Contain, keep evidence, decide what to switch off and tell stores what each shutdown means.[2,9]
Violence or abuse	Make safe, call 999 if anyone is in danger, do not pursue. Colleague first.	Check it is logged and reported, support the manager, make the next shifts safe.
Fire, threat or attack nearby	Evacuate, invacuate or lock down as briefed. Account for colleagues.	Alert nearby stores, convene the incident group, own customer and media lines.
Cold-chain failure	Probe food by hand, take unsafe stock off sale, do not just reset the controller.[6,10]	Call the contractor, find other sites with the same controllers, take them offline.
Rogue message to customers	Expect questions. Use the approved line and do not guess.	Lock the channel used, then tell customers plainly what to ignore.[11]

SEVERITY

A retail severity ladder that stores and head office share

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later.

SEV 1 **Critical**	TRIGGERS Payments, tills or core systems down across many stores or online. A weapon, terror or life-safety incident at any store. Controller tampering at several sites.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Crisis team, all affected store and area managers, IT and security leads, communications and legal. Voice · SMS · push · bridge in 15 min
SEV 2 **Major**	TRIGGERS Outage in one region or one channel. Serious assault on a colleague. Fridge or freezer failure with stock at risk. A credible threat to a store.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Incident manager, area and regional managers, IT or facilities on call, communications on standby. SMS · push · escalate after 10 min
SEV 3 **Moderate**	TRIGGERS Problem at a single store: tills failing, a violent incident without injury, one fridge alarm, an evacuation for a false alarm.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Store manager, area manager, service desk or facilities helpdesk. Push · email
SEV 4 **Minor**	TRIGGERS Verbal abuse logged, a single device fault, a near miss or a suspicious approach to staff.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Store manager, recorded for trend reporting and weekly review. App · email

ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Who does what: store, region and head office

A suggested matrix for a multi-store incident. Agree it before peak and adjust it to your structure.

ACTIVITY	STORE MANAGER	REGIONAL MANAGER	HEAD OFFICE INCIDENT LEAD	IT AND SECURITY	COMMS	LOSS PREVENTION
Raise the first report	A	I	I	I	·	I
Declare and set the severity	C	C	A	C	I	I
Switch to cash and offline	R	R	A	C	I	I
Close one store for safety	A	I	I	·	I	C
Close stores across a region	R	A	C	·	I	I
Contain systems, keep evidence	I	I	A	R	·	C
Chase silent stores	R	A	I	·	·	·
Customer and media statements	I	I	C	C	A	I
Colleague safety and lockdown	A	C	I	·	I	R
Keep CCTV, report to police	R	I	I	·	·	A
Reopen and return to normal	R	R	A	C	I	I

R Responsible: does the work · A Accountable: owns the decision · C Consulted · I Informed

> One rule overrides the matrix: a store manager never needs permission to act on safety. Closing a door, pausing entry or calling 999 is theirs to decide; head office is told straight after.

DECISION RIGHTS

Who closes a store, who goes to cash, who speaks to the media

Name each owner and a deputy before peak. If the owner cannot be reached in ten minutes, the deputy decides.

DECISION	WHO DECIDES	WHO CAN ACT FIRST	WHO MUST BE TOLD
Close a store or pause entry	Store manager for safety; regional manager for trading.	The most senior colleague on the floor.	Regional manager, then the incident lead.
Switch to cash only	Incident lead for the estate; store manager for one store.	Store manager, using the cash procedure.	Regional manager and cash office.
Take systems offline	Incident lead, on IT and security advice.	IT security, only to stop an active attack.	Every store, with what it means for them.
Speak to the media	Communications lead, with the incident lead.	Nobody else. Stores use the holding line.	Regional managers and stores.
Evacuate or lock down	Store manager, or police on arrival.	Any colleague facing an immediate threat.	Regional manager, loss prevention.
Take chilled stock off sale	Store manager, on probe readings.	Any trained colleague.	Facilities and food safety.
Notify regulators and insurers	Incident lead, with legal.	Nobody until it is logged with reasons.	Executive team.

ESCALATION

Escalating from store to region to head office

Four levels that match the severity ladder. The times are suggested starting points; set your own and write them into your alerting rules, so escalation does not depend on someone remembering.

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 1 **Store**	One store: tills failing, an aggressive customer, a single fridge alarm, a false fire alarm.	Store manager, colleagues on shift, the service desk or facilities helpdesk.	Store manager: pause entry, go cash only, take stock off sale, call 999.

↓ ESCALATE IF TWO OR MORE STORES ARE HIT, ANYONE IS HURT, OR THERE IS NO FIX IN 30 MINUTES

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 2 **Region**	The same fault in several stores in one region, a serious assault, stock at risk or a credible threat.	Regional manager, area managers, IT or facilities on call, loss prevention.	Regional manager: close stores in the region, move colleagues, ask head office for support.

↓ ESCALATE IF MORE THAN ONE REGION OR ONLINE IS HIT, OR ANY STORE IS SILENT AFTER 10 MINUTES

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 3 **Head office**	Payments, tills or core systems down across regions or online, a suspected cyber attack, a lockdown or life-safety incident.	Head office incident lead, IT and security, communications, loss prevention, every affected regional manager.	Head office incident lead: estate-wide cash procedure, systems offline, customer messages.

↓ ESCALATE IF TRADING CANNOT RESUME BY THE NEXT UPDATE, OR DATA OR MEDIA ARE INVOLVED

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 4 **Executive crisis team**	Business-wide disruption, a data breach, serious injury or death, sustained media attention.	Executive team, legal, communications director, insurer and incident response provider.	Executive lead: closing the estate or online, public statements, regulator and insurer notifications.

> Silence is a signal. A store that has not acknowledged within ten minutes is chased by its regional manager; a regional manager who has not acknowledged is replaced by their deputy and the head office incident lead is told.

BEFORE BLACK FRIDAY

Peak readiness in six steps

Black Friday falls on 27 November this year. Finish these before then, and repeat the checks before the last trading weekend before Christmas.

01 Freeze change and name the on-call team

No non-essential changes to payments, tills, e-commerce or networks over peak. Publish who is on call for every day, including weekends.

02 Test the offline and cash procedure

Confirm what each till and terminal can do offline, how much cash float stores hold and who decides to go cash only.

03 Rehearse one outage and one lockdown

A 30-minute exercise with store and area managers: a payment failure at 10am on a Saturday, then a lockdown call.

04 Check every contact list

Store, area and regional managers, key suppliers, payment providers and contractors, each with a tested out-of-hours number.

05 Close the doors you forgot

List fridge controllers, building systems and supplier remote access that face the internet, and take them off it.[6,12]

06 Brief colleagues on safety

De-escalation, how to raise an alarm, when not to intervene and who to call. Staff the hotspots, not just the tills.

PART 02

When it happens.

The first hour on the worst day, and the procedures for violence, lockdown and a cold chain you cannot trust.

01 The first hour of a peak outage

02 Across stores, region and head office

03 Tracking what is still outstanding

04 After an assault on a colleague

05 Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

06 A cold-chain incident

07 Messages ready to send

THE FIRST HOUR

Black Friday, 07:40: card payments fail

An illustrative timeline. The cause is not yet known. Act on what you can see, name who decides at each step and watch for the stores that go quiet.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**First reports reach the service desk** Dozens of stores report card terminals declining. Online checkout errors climb.	SERVICE DESK
T+00:05	**Incident declared at SEV 1** Several regions and online are hit. The bridge opens and the log starts.	INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:10	**First instruction to every store** Go to the cash and offline procedure, stop restarting terminals, acknowledge. Stores silent after ten minutes go to their regional manager. Next update 08:30.	RETAIL OPERATIONS
T+00:15	**Find the cause, keep the evidence** Check provider status and internal systems for intrusion. Nothing is switched off without a decision.	SECURITY LEAD
T+00:20	**Protect people, tell customers** Managers may pause entry if queues become unsafe. Banner, social posts and store announcement: open, cash accepted, next update time.	SECURITY · COMMS
T+00:45	**Decide on containment** If attack is suspected: isolate, call the response provider and insurer, assess whether personal data is involved.	SECURITY LEAD · LEGAL
T+01:00	**First update to the crisis team** Stores affected, cash position, customer impact, likely duration, decisions needed, next update.	INCIDENT MANAGER

MULTI-STORE SCENARIO

Black Friday across stores, region and head office

The same illustrative outage, seen lane by lane. Red marks where it usually goes wrong, navy marks who decides, and pale blue marks how progress is watched.

	07:40	07:50	08:00	08:30	09:30	11:00
Affected stores	Cards declined at tills in many stores	! Managers keep restarting terminals; queues build	Stores acknowledge and start the cash procedure	! Cash floats run low in busy stores	Each store confirms cards work again	Cash banked, losses and incidents logged
Regional managers		Alerted by app and SMS; acknowledge	Silent stores chased after ten minutes	◆ Closes two stores with unsafe queues	◆ Reopens stores once terminals are tested	Checks every store reopened and staffed
Head office incident lead		◆ Declares SEV 1 and opens the bridge	◆ Estate-wide switch to cash and offline	◆ Approves isolating systems on security advice	Store status board reviewed every 30 minutes	Stands down; open actions tracked to closure
IT and payments	Service desk sees failures in every region		Provider fault or attack? Evidence kept	! Pressure to restart before the cause is known	Payments restored region by region	Root cause and evidence passed to review
Communications		! Colleagues post online before any statement	Holding line and web banner live	◆ One spokesperson takes media calls	! Update runs late; stores fill the gap	Customer update and thanks to colleagues

Action · Decision · Where it goes wrong · Monitored

> Most failures sit between the lanes: a decision made at head office that nobody tells stores about, or a store problem that never reaches head office. Give each handover an owner and a time.

OUTSTANDING ACTIONS

Saturday 11:00: what is still open

An illustrative actions board three hours in. Every action has one owner, a due time and a way of checking it is done. Review it at every update until it is empty.

ACTION	OWNER	DUE	STATUS	HOW IT IS CHECKED
Confirm every store is taking cards again	Regional managers	11:30	IN PROGRESS	Store status board, store by store
Reopen the two stores closed for queue safety	Regional manager	12:00	OPEN	Terminals tested; reopening logged
Collect cash from stores over their float limit	Cash office	13:00	OPEN	Collection booked and confirmed
Customer FAQ and social media update	Communications	10:45	OVERDUE	Escalated to the incident lead at due time
Root cause statement from the payment provider	IT lead	17:00	BLOCKED	Chased at every update; waiting on provider
Reconcile offline and failed card transactions	Finance and IT	Sun 10:00	IN PROGRESS	Matched against the provider report
Aftercare for the colleague pushed in a queue	Loss prevention	Today	DONE	Call logged; incident report filed
Decide whether to notify the ICO and the insurer	Incident lead, legal	Sun 12:00	OPEN	Decision and reasons recorded in the log
Book the post-incident review	Incident lead	Mon	DONE	Invite sent with the review template

> Overdue and blocked actions are raised at the next update, not left on the board. The incident lead decides whether to chase, reassign or escalate, and the decision goes in the log. The board closes only when every action is done or handed to the post-incident review.

STORE STATUS LOG

Store status log: one line per store, every update

Regional managers keep this for their stores during a multi-store incident, or head office keeps it for the estate. It shows at a glance who has heard, who is trading and who needs help.

STORE	ALERTED	ACKNOWLEDGED	TRADING STATUS	SAFETY OR QUEUE ISSUE	STOCK AT RISK	NEXT CHECK	INITIALS
Store 0147, North	*07:52*	*07:58, manager*	*Open, cash only*	*Long queue, entry paused 08:20*	*None*	*08:30*	*RM*

Trading status: open, cash only, closed for safety, closed for trading. A store with no acknowledgement after ten minutes is chased and marked in red at the next update.

VIOLENCE AND ABUSE

After an assault on a colleague: six steps that matter

The BRC estimates over 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff a day, 118 of them physically violent.[8]

01 Make safe and get help

Call 999 if anyone is hurt or in danger. Do not detain or follow the offender.

02 Look after the colleague

First aid, a quiet room, someone with them, a safe way home. Not back on the till.

03 Keep the evidence

Secure CCTV and body-worn video, note witnesses, write it up within the shift.

04 Report it, every time

Report to police and keep the reference. The new offence of assaulting a retail worker is enacted but not yet in force.[13]

05 Tell head office within the hour

One message, one channel: area manager, security and HR hear the same facts.

06 Follow up and learn

Call the colleague next day, review staffing and layout, share intelligence locally.

MARTYN'S LAW PROCEDURES

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 will require shops where 200 or more people can be expected at once to have these four procedures, so far as is reasonably practicable. The duties are not yet in force.[14]

Evacuation

Getting people away from danger by moving them out of the premises. Know your exits, assembly points and who sweeps each area.[14]

Invacuation

Moving people to a safer place inside, such as a stockroom or back corridor away from glass and entrances.[14]

Lockdown

Securing the premises to stop people entering or leaving. Know which doors lock, who locks them and how fast.[14]

Communication

Getting information to everyone on site: colleagues, customers and contractors, with a way to reach staff who are off the shop floor.[14]

The implementation period is at least 24 months from Royal Assent on 3 April 2025. Premises expecting 800 or more people fall into the enhanced tier, with wider duties.[14]

COLD CHAIN

When you cannot trust the fridge

Refrigeration controllers have been tampered with remotely across Europe this autumn. Treat an unexplained defrost as a possible attack until you know otherwise.

Spot it

An alarm, a case warming for no reason or a defrost cycle outside its schedule.

Check the food, not the display

Probe product temperatures by hand. In England, Wales and Northern Ireland chilled food must legally be kept at 8°C or below.[10]

Take it off sale

Remove anything you cannot show stayed at a safe temperature. Record what, where and when for the insurer and food safety team.

Cut the remote link

With the contractor, take controllers off the internet and allow access only through a secure VPN. CERT-FR warns a factory reset alone is not enough for end-of-life kit.[6]

Restore and check every site

Reconfigure, check defrost schedules, then look for the same controllers at every other store and depot.[6,12]

Check your insurance conditions before cutting data links to the refrigeration contractor, as CERT-FR advises.[6]

COLD-CHAIN RECORD

Cold-chain quarantine record

Fill one line for every case or unit you check after an unexplained defrost or alarm. Chilled food must be kept at 8°C or below in England, Wales and Northern Ireland.[10] The record supports the insurer, the food safety team and the review.

CASE OR UNIT	PRODUCT OR SECTION	PROBE READING AND TIME	DISPLAY READING	ACTION TAKEN	QUANTITY AND VALUE	CHECKED BY
Freezer 3, aisle 9	*Frozen desserts*	*-4°C at 06:15*	*-18°C*	*Off sale, held for insurer*	*42 units*	*Duty manager*

Probe the food, not the display: the display reading comes from the controller you may not be able to trust. Do not reset the controller or restock until remote access has been cut and the contractor has checked it.

MESSAGES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and honest. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause, and always give the time of the next update.

SMS · STORE MANAGERS

146 chars

> SEV1: Card payments down in many stores. Switch to cash and offline procedure now. Do not restart terminals. Reply 1 when done. Next update 08:30.

Keep it under 160 characters so it arrives as one message.

PUSH · ALL STORE COLLEAGUES

> Some payment systems are down. Your safety comes first. Stay calm, use the till script, call security if anyone becomes aggressive. Please do not post about this online.

WEB BANNER · CUSTOMERS

> We're sorry: some card payments aren't working in our stores right now. Stores are open and accepting [cash]. We're working to fix it and will update here at [10:00].

Only say what you know is true. Add what still works.

EMAIL · SUPPLIERS AND HAULIERS

> We are managing an IT incident affecting [systems]. Deliveries continue as booked unless we call you. Do not act on any request to change bank details or give access. Verify on [known number].

Attackers often follow up with fake supplier requests.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of an issue affecting payments in some of our stores and are working to resolve it as quickly as possible. Our stores remain open. We will share more information as soon as we can.

SMS · STORE MANAGER, COLD CHAIN

153 chars

> SEV2: Fridge controller alarm at your store. Probe food temps now. Do not reset the controller. Take unsafe stock off sale. Reply 1, then call [FM line].

PART 03

Recover and rehearse.

Three scenarios to test your plan, a tabletop exercise, a dated plan with owners, the questions to put to your leadership team and a review template.

01 Three scenarios

02 A tabletop exercise

03 This week, this month, this quarter

04 Questions and checklist

05 The post-incident review

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse before peak

GROCER, 400 STORES

Card terminals fail on the last Saturday before Christmas

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

A provider outage hits two regions at 10am. Stores wait for certainty and give customers different answers.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Acknowledgement per store, chased at ten minutes, and a status board reviewed every 30 minutes.

WHO DECIDES

The head office incident lead calls the estate-wide cash switch; regional managers close unsafe stores.

REHEARSE

Run one store on cash only for 30 minutes.

CONVENIENCE CHAIN, FRANCHISE AND COMPANY STORES

Freezers defrost overnight in a dozen stores

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Opening staff reset controllers and restock before anyone cuts the remote access they share.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

A quarantine record per store and a site list of controllers, ticked off as each is checked.

WHO DECIDES

Store managers take stock off sale; the head office lead orders controllers offline at every site.

REHEARSE

Ask area managers to name their controller models.

FASHION RETAILER, FLAGSHIP STORE

An aggressive group, then a call to lock down

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

A tannoy nobody hears upstairs, and no list of who is on shift or who locks which door.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Each floor confirms it is secure and every colleague is accounted for against the shift list.

WHO DECIDES

The store manager locks down without waiting; police take over on arrival; head office supports.

REHEARSE

A ten-minute lockdown walk-through each quarter.

TABLETOP EXERCISE

Exercise: tills down on Super Saturday

An illustrative 90-minute exercise for store, regional and head office leads. Read each inject aloud, give the room five minutes, and record every decision, owner and gap.

DURATION	PARTICIPANTS	OBJECTIVE	FACILITATOR
90 minutes, six injects	Store and regional managers, head office lead, IT, comms, loss prevention	Test decision rights and store acknowledgement across many stores	Head of resilience or an external facilitator

09:55	INJECT 1 Card payments fail in 120 stores across three regions. Online checkout is slow.	DISCUSS Who declares, at what level? What is the first instruction to stores, and by when?
10:10	INJECT 2 Eighteen stores have not acknowledged. Two regional managers are on leave.	DISCUSS How do you know who is silent? Who covers for the absent regional managers?
10:30	INJECT 3 A queue in a large store turns hostile and a colleague is pushed.	DISCUSS Who decides to pause entry or close? What support does the colleague get, and who checks?
10:50	INJECT 4 IT finds signs of intrusion and wants to take the store network offline.	DISCUSS Who approves? What will stores lose, and who tells them before it happens?
11:15	INJECT 5 A journalist calls a store directly. A video of the queue is spreading online.	DISCUSS Who speaks for the business? What does the store say, word for word?
13:00	INJECT 6 Freezer alarms in six stores. They share the same controller model.	DISCUSS Is it connected? Who decides on stock, and who checks every other site?

> Afterwards, score yourselves on the readiness assessment, put every gap on the outstanding actions board with an owner and a date, and run the exercise again before the last trading weekend before Christmas.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Publish the peak on-call rota and change freeze. Send the severity ladder and the six message templates to every store.	Head of resilience
This week	Test the cash and offline procedure in one store per region. Confirm payment provider escalation contacts.	Retail operations director
This month	Take fridge controllers and other building systems off the internet. Review supplier remote access.	Facilities and IT security
This month	Brief every store on violence response and reporting. Check alarms, body-worn video and radios work.	Head of security
This quarter	Map stores likely to be in scope of Martyn's Law and draft the four procedures for each format.	Head of security, with legal
This quarter	Run a joint store and head office exercise on a cyber outage. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Chief operating officer

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

TRADING

- ? If every card terminal failed at 10am on a Saturday, how long until every store had one clear instruction?
- ? Which head office shutdown decisions would stop stores trading, and who tells them?
- ? Do we know which store systems and fridge controllers face the internet today?

PEOPLE

- ? Is every assault on a colleague reported, followed up and visible to the board?
- ? Could each large store evacuate, invacuate or lock down today, and has it practised?
- ? How would we reach colleagues who are off shift or off the shop floor?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready for peak?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **One severity ladder used by stores and head office**
  With named owners for each level.
- [ ] **Peak on-call rota and change freeze published**
  Covering every trading day to the new year.
- [ ] **Cash and offline procedure tested this month**
  In at least one store per region.
- [ ] **Message templates approved and loaded**
  Store managers, colleagues, customers, suppliers and media.
- [ ] **Fridge controllers and building systems off the internet**
  Remote access only through a secure route.
- [ ] **Every assault reported and followed up**
  With aftercare for the colleague and a store risk review.
- [ ] **Evacuation, invacuation and lockdown briefed**
  And walked through in large stores.
- [ ] **Every store acknowledges alerts**
  And non-responders are chased automatically.

POST-INCIDENT REVIEW

Post-incident review template

Hold the review within two weeks, with stores in the room as well as head office. Look for causes, not culprits, and turn every finding into a dated action.

INCIDENT	DATE	SEVERITY	REVIEW LEAD

01 What happened

A timeline from the first store report to stand down, built from the incident log, not from memory.

02 Detection and first report

How was it first spotted in store? How long until head office knew, and how?

03 Alerting and acknowledgement

Which stores acknowledged, and how fast? Who stayed silent, and why?

04 Decisions and decision rights

Who decided to close stores, go to cash or take systems offline? Were they the right people?

05 Stores and colleagues

Trading lost, stores closed, colleagues hurt or abused, aftercare given and still needed.

06 Customers, media and suppliers

What was said, when and by whom? Was it accurate, and did stores know first?

07 What worked and what did not

Procedures, tools, contact lists and handovers between store, region and head office.

08 Actions, owners and dates

Every finding becomes an action with one owner and a due date, tracked to closure and reported.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Severity level
A shared grade (SEV 1 to SEV 4) that sets who is alerted, how fast and how often.

Offline payment mode
A terminal setting that stores some card transactions for later authorisation when the network is down.

Change freeze
A period, usually over peak, when only essential changes to systems are allowed.

Invacuation
Moving people to a safer place inside a building, away from danger outside.

Lockdown
Securing a building so people cannot enter or leave until it is safe.

Martyn's Law
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, which sets duties for larger public premises.

Cold chain
Keeping chilled and frozen food at safe temperatures from supplier to shelf.

Refrigeration controller
A device that runs fridges and freezers and can often be managed remotely.

Defrost cycle
A scheduled warm-up that clears ice. Stretched or repeated, it spoils stock.

Acknowledgement
A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Incident manager
The person who runs the response, keeps the log and sets the rhythm of updates.

Holding line
A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

Body-worn video
A camera worn by colleagues or security staff that records incidents as evidence.

Responsible person
Under Martyn's Law, the person or organisation in control of qualifying premises.

Remote access
A route for suppliers or engineers to manage systems from outside the store.

End of life
When a manufacturer stops issuing security fixes for a product.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

When card payments fail on Black Friday, a message to stores is minute one. Trading through it depends on which stores acknowledged, who switched to the fallback, what customers were told, and an accurate picture for head office.

WHERE INCIDENTS GO WRONG

01	**Fragmented information**	Different teams work from different information.
02	**Delayed decision making**	Leadership lacks visibility, so decisions wait.
03	**Uncoordinated response**	Several teams work independently on the same problem.
04	**Lack of visibility**	Critical actions become difficult to track.
05	**Lack of accountability**	Actions and decisions are poorly documented.

THE WHOLE INCIDENT, IN ONE PLATFORM



Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. It helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform.

THE PLATFORM

One connected platform, from first alert to final report.

Crises Control helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform. Each module does one job; the value comes from how they work together across the incident.

01 ESCALATE
SOS
Frontline staff report an incident in one touch from a mobile device.

02 START
Ping
Alerting and activation: reach people and collect acknowledgements and responses.

03 COORDINATE
Incident Manager
Activate the incident, assign roles, control communication and keep the timeline.

04 EXECUTE
Task Manager
Assign actions, track completion and escalate what stalls, with clear accountability.

05 OPERATE
Control Centre
Real-time view of incidents, timelines, task status and assets.

06 PROVE
Audit & Reporting
Incident records, response analysis and task accountability, ready to report.

07 ASSIST
CRAiG
AI assistant that helps users find information and work through the incident.

THE OUTCOMES

Alerting and activation
Reach the right people immediately.

Operational coordination
Structure communication and response activities.

Execution and visibility
Track tasks, responsibilities and progress.

Proof and accountability
Create a complete, defensible operational record.

Most organisations start with the capability they need today, often alerting, and expand as their requirements mature. Highlighted modules are the ones this playbook draws on.

HOW THE MODULES WORK TOGETHER

How the modules work together in a retail incident

The Black Friday outage from this playbook, step by step, from the first report in a store to the record for insurers and the review.

01	ESCALATE **SOS**	A store manager reports tills down in one touch, with the store location, instead of queuing for the service desk.
02	START **Ping**	Every store manager receives the cash procedure on more than one channel; silent stores escalate to their regional manager.
03	COORDINATE **Incident Manager**	Head office declares SEV 1, assigns store, regional and head office roles and keeps one log of every decision.
04	EXECUTE **Task Manager**	The cash procedure, queue safety and reopening checks become owned tasks in every store, with deadlines and escalation.
05	OPERATE **Control Centre**	Head office and regional managers see which stores are trading, cash only, closed or behind on tasks, live.
06	PROVE **Audit & Reporting**	A timestamped record of messages, acknowledgements and decisions is ready for insurers, the ICO and the review.
07	ASSIST **CRAiG**	CRAiG helps the incident team find which stores have not acknowledged or have overdue tasks.

COORDINATION
Everyone works from the same incident, roles and log.

VISIBILITY
Leaders see progress without chasing for updates.

EXECUTION
Every action has an owner, a deadline and an escalation.

ACCOUNTABILITY
The record of what happened builds itself as you go.

READINESS ASSESSMENT

How ready is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your retail organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 · ACTIVATION **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Every store manager and on-call colleague reached in minutes, on more than one channel.	0 1 2 3
02 · ACTIVATION **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Store-by-store acknowledgement, with escalation when a store stays silent.	0 1 2 3
03 · COORDINATION **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation from store to region to head office runs by rule.	0 1 2 3
04 · COORDINATION **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by IT, store operations, loss prevention and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 · EXECUTION **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Fallback, lockdown and cold-chain procedures run as owned tasks in every store.	0 1 2 3
06 · EXECUTION **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Head office sees which stores are trading, closed or at risk, live.	0 1 2 3
07 · ASSURANCE **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline for insurers, the ICO or a post-incident review, ready the next day.	0 1 2 3
08 · ASSURANCE **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Peak-trading scenarios rehearsed with stores, not only at head office.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

SOURCES

Sources and notes

Accessed November 2026. Early reporting on live incidents can change.

01 M&S, Full Year Results 2024/25, 21 May 2025, https://corporate.marksandspencer.com/newsroom/press-releases/full-year-results-52-weeks-ended-29-march-2025

02 Reuters via Insurance Journal, After 46-day cyberattack pause, M&S resumes online orders, 10 June 2025, https://amp.insurancejournal.com/news/international/2025/06/10/826904.htm

03 Co-operative News, Co-op Group says cyber attack cost £206m in lost sales in half-year report, 25 September 2025, https://www.thenews.coop/co-op-group-says-cyber-attack-cost-206m-in-lost-sales-in-half-year-report/

04 Food Manufacture, 6.5m Co-op members had data stolen in cyberattack, 18 July 2025, https://www.foodmanufacture.co.uk/Article/2025/07/18/65m-co-op-members-had-data-stolen-in-cyberattack

05 Ahold Delhaize, Q3 2026 results, 4 November 2026, https://newsroom.aholddelhaize.com/ahold-delhaize-reports-resilient-q3-2026-results-and-updates-2026-guidance-to-reflect-business-disruption-caused-by-recent-cybersecurity-incident/

06 CERT-FR, Alert CERTFR-2026-ALE-012 on refrigeration remote controllers, 12 October 2026 (updated 13 and 16 October), https://cert.cyber.gouv.fr/alerte/CERTFR-2026-ALE-012/

07 Retail Gazette, UK food suppliers hit by cyber attacks targeting fridge and freezer systems, 5 November 2026, https://www.retailgazette.co.uk/blog/2026/11/uk-food-suppliers-hit-by-cyber-attacks-targeting-fridge-and-freezer-systems/

08 British Retail Consortium, BRC Crime Report 2026, 24 February 2026, https://brc.org.uk/media/bk1n3umn/crime-survey-2026.pdf

09 Just Drinks, Albert Heijn resumes online deliveries after cyber outage, 23 October 2026, https://www.just-drinks.com/news/albert-heijn-resumes-online-deliveries-after-cyber-outage/

10 Food Standards Agency, Chilling food correctly in your business, https://www.food.gov.uk/business-guidance/chilling-food-correctly-in-your-business

11 BleepingComputer, ASOS links data breach to social engineering attack, credential theft, 8 October 2026, https://www.bleepingcomputer.com/news/security/asos-links-data-breach-to-social-engineering-attack-credential-theft/

12 Help Net Security, US agencies warn attackers are targeting refrigeration systems (CISA and FBI joint advisory), 6 November 2026, https://www.helpnetsecurity.com/2026/11/06/cyberattacks-refrigeration-systems-cisa-fbi/

13 Crime and Policing Act 2026, section 45: Assault of retail worker (prospective), https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2026/20/section/45

14 Home Office, Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 factsheets (overarching; standard duty requirements), updated 24 July 2026, https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/terrorism-protection-of-premises-act-2025-factsheets

BOOK YOUR RETAIL PLATFORM DEMONSTRATION

Watch a multi-store outage run end to end.

A live, 30-minute demonstration built around a retail incident. You will see one incident move through the whole platform, not a tour of features, and you can bring your own scenario.

WHAT YOU WILL SEE

01	SOS	A store manager reports tills down, with location.
02	PING	Store managers and regional managers are alerted; each store acknowledges.
03	INCIDENT MANAGER	Head office activates the incident and assigns store, regional and head office roles.
04	TASK MANAGER	Fallback, customer messaging and cash procedures become tasks in every store.
05	CONTROL CENTRE	Head office sees which stores are trading, closed or at risk.
06	AUDIT & REPORTING	The incident timeline is produced for insurers and the review.
07	CRAIG	CRAiG shows which stores have overdue tasks.

Book your demonstration →

crises-control.com/retail-incident-management-software/

+44 (0) 20 8584 1385 · contactus@crises-control.com

SCAN TO BOOK

COMPANION REPORT When the tills go dark